



THE ADVENTURER'S GUILD

CHARACTER CREATION GUIDE

Registry Handbook for New Adventurers and Guild Applicants

A practical guide for creating characters in D&D 5e and the revised 5e rules, commonly called 5.5e, for service in the Oathbound campaign.

THE SEVEN STEPS OF CHARACTER CREATION



GUILD MAXIM *The Guild can train a recruit, equip an adventurer, and open a road. It cannot supply the reason a person chooses to walk it.*

Issued for use at Session 0, during character revision, and whenever a new adventurer joins the company.

Campaign authority rests with the Dungeon Master.

1. PURPOSE AND QUICK START

This guide turns a character idea into an adventurer who can enter the Oathbound campaign, work beside the party, and belong in either Faerûn or the homebrewed world of Avadon. It is both a rules checklist and a record of the choices that make the character worth remembering.

FIRST PRINCIPLE *Create a person first and a collection of abilities second. Strong statistics can solve a scene; a strong character gives the scene meaning.*

The Seven-Step Path

1. Concept — Describe the adventurer in one sentence.
2. Rules — Choose the rules framework and record every source.
3. Origin — Decide whether the character is from Faerûn, Avadon, or somewhere beyond either world.
4. Heritage — Select species, culture, languages, faith, and background.
5. Calling — Choose class, subclass path, abilities, and equipment.
6. History — Write the people, events, duties, and failures that shaped the character.
7. Guild Bond — Give the character a reason to join, cooperate, and remain with the party.

A Character Is Ready When...

- ☐ The player can explain the character in two or three sentences.
- ☐ Every mechanical choice has a named sourcebook and rules version.
- ☐ The required physical sourcebooks are available to the player.
- ☐ The character has a reason to adventure and a reason to cooperate.
- ☐ The character fits the selected world of origin.
- ☐ The Dungeon Master has approved the final sheet and backstory.

Campaign Foundation

TONE The story may begin lightheartedly, but serious challenges, difficult choices, and emotional consequences will grow with the party.	THEMES Teamwork, camaraderie, moral dilemmas, exploration, character growth, and the legacy created by the party's choices.
STARTING POINT Create the complete Level 1 character. The Dungeon Master will provide any temporary Level 0 adjustments used for the opening prologue.	GUILD STATUS Level 0 characters begin as applicants or prospective recruits. Successful initiation places them among the Guild's Bronze-ranked adventurers.

2. RULES SOURCES AND TABLE ELIGIBILITY

Players may create characters using material from Dungeons & Dragons Fifth Edition and the revised Fifth Edition rules commonly called 5.5e, subject to the source and compatibility rules below.

The Physical Book Requirement

SOURCE RULE *A character option is eligible only when it appears in an officially published or officially licensed D&D 5e or revised 5e physical book that the player owns, can bring, or can make available for rules reference.*

- Record the title of the physical book beside each species, class, subclass, background, feat, spell, and unusual equipment choice.
- Be prepared to produce the book when the character is approved or when a rules question depends upon that option.
- A D&D Beyond entry does not replace the physical-book requirement, though D&D Beyond remains the preferred character-sheet platform.
- Setting-specific material is permitted when it meets the source requirement. Its story details may be adapted so the option belongs in the campaign world.

Material That Requires Separate Approval

- Unearthed Arcana, playtest packets, unlicensed third-party books, fan-created material, and homebrew are not automatically eligible.
- A player may propose such material to the Dungeon Master, but it should not be treated as approved until the Dungeon Master says so explicitly.
- A published option may still be adjusted when its assumptions conflict with the campaign, another rules edition, or a significant setting element.

Rules Ledger

Character Element	Choice	Sourcebook	Edition / Year
Species / Lineage			
Background			
Class			
Subclass			
Feat(s)			
Key Spell or Feature			

Character Element	Choice	Sourcebook	Edition / Year
Other			

REGISTRAR’S NOTE *The purpose of the ledger is not to burden the player. It lets the table resolve questions quickly and protects every character from accidental rules mixing.*

3. USING 5E AND REVISED 5E TOGETHER

Both the 2014 Fifth Edition rules and the 2024 revised rules may appear at the same table. A character may draw from either body of officially permitted material, but the character must remain understandable, internally consistent, and fair to the rest of the party.

Compatibility Rules

- Choose a foundation.** Identify whether the character’s class and core character-building rules primarily follow the 2014 or revised rules.
- Use one version of a feature.** When a class, spell, feat, species, or other option exists in multiple versions under the same name, select one version rather than combining the strongest pieces of both.
- Do not double-count origin benefits.** Ability-score increases and similar origin benefits come from the rules framework being used. A character does not receive both the older species-based increases and the revised background-based increases unless the Dungeon Master specifically directs it.
- Mark differences clearly.** Place the book title and edition beside any option likely to be confused with another version.
- Accept table rulings.** When the two rules sets interact in an unclear way, the Dungeon Master’s ruling governs the campaign unless the group later adopts a written house rule.

Recommended Character Record

RULES FOUNDATION 2014 5e / Revised 5e	CLASS VERSION Book and publication year
ORIGIN ABILITY SCORES Species-based / Background-based / DM ruling	SPELL VERSION Use one printed version when duplicate names exist
PRIMARY SHEET D&D Beyond, with source notes added where needed	FINAL AUTHORITY The campaign’s written house rules and Dungeon Master rulings

TABLE COURTESY *Build the character you are excited to play, not a rules dispute the group must repeatedly solve. When a combination is uncertain, bring it to the Dungeon Master before the session.*

Character Rules Declaration

Primary Rules Foundation: _____

Class and Version: _____

Known Cross-Edition Choices: _____

Dungeon Master Ruling Needed: _____

4. CREATE THE ADVENTURER BEFORE THE STATISTICS

Begin with a concept broad enough to grow and specific enough to make choices. The best concept tells the group what the character does, what the character wants, and what might make the journey difficult.

The One-Sentence Concept

FORMULA *A [role, calling, or identity] who [defining goal], but [burden, fear, obligation, or contradiction].*

Examples:

- A disgraced royal cartographer who wants to map the roads between worlds, but fears every discovery will lead her former court to the people protecting her.
- A village healer who joined the Guild to find a cure for a spreading curse, but secretly doubts whether the gods still hear him.
- A cheerful sellsword who treats every contract as a game, but refuses to leave another companion behind after surviving a disastrous expedition.

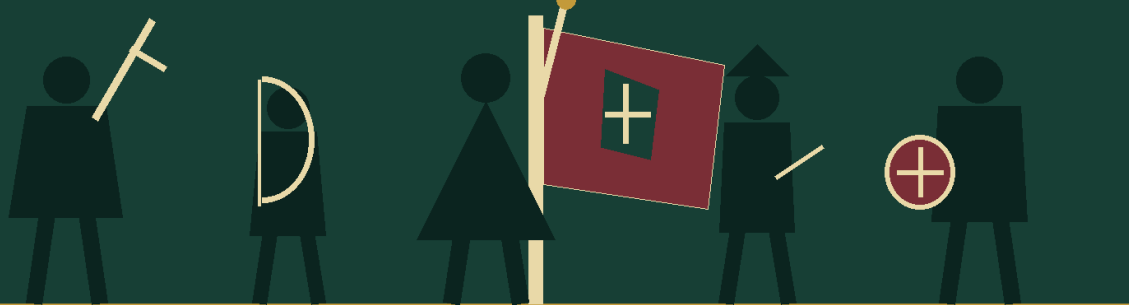
Four Questions Every Concept Must Answer

1. What can this adventurer contribute when danger begins?
2. What does this adventurer want badly enough to leave safety behind?
3. Why will this adventurer work with the party instead of walking away?
4. What could this adventurer become by Level 20 that they are not yet ready to be?

Party-Safe Character Design

- Create someone who can disagree without destroying the campaign's cooperative foundation.
- Do not rely on theft from companions, routine betrayal, secret hostility toward the entire party, or refusal to participate as the character's central identity.
- A difficult, selfish, criminal, or morally complicated character can work when the player gives them a believable reason to remain loyal to the group.
- Private secrets are welcome. A secret that removes another player's agency or requires the campaign to revolve around one character requires advance agreement.

A PARTY IS MORE THAN FIVE CHARACTER SHEETS



Build someone who has a reason to stand beside the others when the road turns dark.

5. CHOOSE THE WORLD OF ORIGIN

A character may come from Faerûn, from Avadon, or—when approved—from another plane or world. The choice determines which lore the player may safely assume and which details should be created with the Dungeon Master.



Characters from Faerûn

- Published setting lore may be used as a starting point, provided it fits the campaign's established history.
- Choose a homeland, culture, faith or philosophy, and one reason the character would answer the Adventurer's Guild's call.
- The campaign can connect willing characters to familiar threats, factions, and story traditions without requiring extensive setting knowledge.

Characters from Avadon

- Avadon is a homebrewed world. Published Faerûn lore does not automatically describe Avadon's nations, species, religions, organizations, or magical traditions.
- Work with the Dungeon Master before finalizing facts that depend upon world history, geography, culture, politics, faith, or the legal treatment of magic.
- A player does not need to learn the entire world. Build the small circle of places, people, and beliefs that the character would realistically know.
- Mechanical options from published books may be reflavored to fit Avadon while keeping their game rules intact, subject to Dungeon Master approval.

AVADON PRINCIPLE *Ask for the lore that matters to the character now. Leave room for the world—and the character's understanding of it—to grow during play.*

6. THE AVADON COLLABORATION RECORD

Use this page with the Dungeon Master when creating an Avadon native. It separates facts the character knows from mysteries the campaign may reveal later.

Three Anchors

A PLACE Where did the character grow up, and what does that place value or fear?	A PERSON Who taught, protected, employed, betrayed, or still depends upon the character?
AN OBLIGATION What debt, promise, oath, duty, or unfinished responsibility follows the character?	AN UNANSWERED QUESTION What part of the character's past is uncertain, hidden, or misunderstood?

Questions to Resolve with the Dungeon Master

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Homeland, settlement, region, or traveling culture | ☐ Local laws, rulers, factions, and conflicts |
| ☐ Species or ancestry traditions relevant to the character | ☐ Technology, trade, travel, and everyday life |
| ☐ Languages and naming conventions | ☐ Historical event that shaped the character or family |
| ☐ Religion, gods, spirits, or philosophy | ☐ Whether the character knows the Adventurer's Guild by reputation |
| ☐ Common attitudes toward magic and spellcasters | ☐ Any lore the player should intentionally not know yet |

Avadon Character Notes

Homeland / Culture: _____

Faith / Philosophy: _____

Important Faction or Institution: _____

Relevant Law or Custom: _____

What the Character Believes About Magic: _____

One Fact the DM Confirmed: _____

One Question Left Open: _____

LORE BOUNDARY *The Dungeon Master may revise a proposed detail that conflicts with established Avadon lore. The goal is not to reject the character, but to place the character where their history can matter.*

7. BUILD THE CHARACTER

- Once the concept and world are clear, complete the mechanical character. Use the order below so later choices support the original idea rather than replacing it.
- ◆ **Choose Species or Lineage:** Select an eligible option, then decide what parts of its published culture apply to this individual and this world.
 - ◆ **Choose Background:** Use the background to answer what the character did before adventuring, which skills they practiced, and what relationships or duties still remain.
 - ◆ **Choose Class:** Select the class that best expresses how the character meets danger. Record the rules version and sourcebook.
 - ◆ **Plan the Subclass:** Even when the subclass is not gained at Level 1, identify the intended path so the story can foreshadow it. The choice may still change through play.
 - ◆ **Assign Ability Scores:** Use the Standard Array: 15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8. Apply origin increases according to the chosen rules framework and any Dungeon Master ruling.
 - ◆ **Select Skills and Proficiencies:** Avoid choosing only for numerical efficiency. Skills should also show training, profession, culture, or lived experience.
 - ◆ **Choose Equipment:** Begin with the normal Level 1 equipment granted by the chosen rules. The Dungeon Master will identify any Level 0 limitations or substitutions.
 - ◆ **Choose Spells and Features:** Record the source and version of any option likely to differ between editions. Know the basic function of the abilities selected.

Campaign Character-Building Rules

ABILITY SCORES Standard Array: 15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8.	ENCUMBRANCE Encumbrance is used. Track what the character carries and how it is transported.
COIN WEIGHT Coin weight is ignored. Guild coinage is magical and may compress or exchange denominations without adding carried weight.	OPTIONAL FEATURES Official optional character features may be used when compatible with the selected rules framework.
STARTING GEAR Build the complete Level 1 equipment package; Level 0 changes are handled by the Dungeon Master.	CHARACTER SHEET Use D&D Beyond unless the Dungeon Master approves another sheet format.

8. WRITE A BACKSTORY THAT CAN ENTER PLAY

A useful backstory gives the Dungeon Master material to bring forward without predetermining the character's entire future. It should explain the character's starting point, not complete the character's greatest adventure before Session 1.

Recommended Length and Structure

- Aim for one to three pages, or an equivalent outline that can be understood quickly.
- Lead with the facts most likely to matter at the table. Additional history may be developed later.
- Name important people and places, but leave some details flexible until the world connection is confirmed.

The Five Backstory Elements

- 1. Origin:** Where did the character come from, and what kind of life felt normal there?
- 2. Turning Point:** What event ended the old life or made it impossible to remain unchanged?
- 3. Relationship:** Who matters enough to influence the character's choices from afar?
- 4. Burden:** What mistake, loss, duty, secret, enemy, curse, or debt still has power over the character?
- 5. Forward Goal:** What does the character hope the Guild and the journey will make possible?

Optional Oathbound Story Threads

A player may ask the Dungeon Master to connect the character to one of the following campaign traditions. These are invitations, not requirements, and may be adapted for Avadon or Faerûn.

THE DRAGON CULT A survivor, defector, investigator, relative, victim, scholar, or former servant tied to draconic schemes and the legacy of Tiamat.	THE THIEVES' GUILD A former operative, debtor, rival, protected asset, escaped recruit, or investigator tied to criminal networks and hidden bargains.
THE VAMPIRE A family curse, vanished patron, hunter's oath, survivor's guilt, forbidden affection, or debt to an immortal power.	THE FAE ENTITY A childhood bargain, stolen name, inherited promise, strange blessing, lost memory, or obligation to a being whose gifts carry rules of their own.

BACKSTORY LIMIT *Do not write outcomes for important nonplayer characters, nations, deities, or setting mysteries without approval. Offer possibilities; let the campaign decide what proved true.*

9. PERSONALITY, RELATIONSHIPS, AND GROWTH

Personality should create choices, not prevent play. The following traits give the character a recognizable voice while leaving room for change.

Four Character Foundations

TRAIT A habit, manner, preference, or emotional pattern the other characters will notice.	IDEAL A principle the character wants to believe, especially when following it is costly.
BOND A person, place, object, cause, oath, or memory the character will act to protect.	FLAW A fear, temptation, prejudice, coping mechanism, or mistaken belief that creates meaningful trouble.

Create Relationships Before Play

Pre-established relationships between player characters are optional, but each player should be willing to discuss at least one possible connection. A shared contact or brief prior encounter is enough.

- We survived the same event, but remember it differently.
- One of us was hired to guide, protect, investigate, teach, arrest, or find the other.
- Our families, mentors, patrons, factions, or faiths know one another.
- We owe the same person—or the same person owes both of us.
- We met once before and each formed the wrong first impression.

Growth Questions

What belief is the character most likely to question? _____

What would make the character feel they finally belong? _____

What kind of power would tempt the character to compromise? _____

Who might the character become if the party brings out their best qualities?

What legacy does the character want the world to remember? _____

10. BIND THE CHARACTER TO THE ADVENTURER'S GUILD

The Adventurer's Guild is not merely a source of quests. It is the campaign's shared institution, a place where characters find resources, obligations, rivals, mentors, and a growing reputation. Every character needs a reason to step through its doors and sign their name.

The Four Guild Questions

Why Join? What can the Guild offer that the character cannot easily obtain alone—training, legitimacy, protection, knowledge, travel, wealth, allies, redemption, or access to dangerous work?

Why Accept the Character? What skill, experience, courage, knowledge, connection, or potential makes the applicant worth the Guild's time?

Why Stay? What will keep the character committed when the Guild becomes demanding, imperfect, or politically complicated?

What Is at Stake? What does failure to earn a place in the Guild cost the character personally?

Guild Applicant Prompts

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ I first heard of the Adventurer's Guild when... | ☐ A quest I would struggle to accept is... |
| ☐ The Guild member or story I admire is... | ☐ The one resource I hope to earn from the Guild is... |
| ☐ The Guild member or reputation I distrust is... | ☐ The promise I am prepared to make to the party is... |
| ☐ A quest I would accept without hesitation is... | ☐ The deed I hope will one day define my legacy is... |

Entrance and Rank

- The character begins the campaign as an applicant, prospective recruit, or person newly drawn into the Guild's orbit.
- The entrance examination measures aptitude through magical devices, practical trials, and illusionary challenges.
- Upon successful initiation, the adventurer enters the Guild's Bronze rank, serving alongside other new members and earning Quest Points, coin, and reputation through completed work.

GUILD STANDARD *The Guild does not require every member to be noble. It requires every member to be dependable when other lives rest upon their choice.*

11. LEVEL 0, EQUIPMENT, AND CAMPAIGN MATERIALS

The Level 0 Prologue

Players should create a complete Level 1 character. For the campaign's Level 0 opening, the Dungeon Master may temporarily limit features, equipment, hit points, spellcasting, or other abilities to represent the character before full initiation. These adjustments are campaign tools, not permanent changes to the Level 1 build.

- Keep the complete Level 1 sheet as the intended character build.
- Record temporary Level 0 changes separately so they can be removed cleanly after initiation.
- Use the prologue to discover voice, relationships, fears, and goals before every class feature is available.

Equipment and Encumbrance

- Choose the normal starting equipment or starting wealth allowed by the selected class and rules source, subject to Dungeon Master approval.
- Track carried weight and containers because encumbrance is in use.
- Coin weight is ignored because the campaign's magical coinage can compress and exchange denominations without burdening the bearer.
- Unusual, setting-specific, military, restricted, or magical equipment should be discussed before it is placed on the final sheet.

Player Materials

D&D BEYOND CHARACTER SHEET Complete the Level 1 build and share it with the Dungeon Master.	HERO FORGE MINIATURE Create a miniature that reflects the character's recognizable appearance and adventuring equipment.
CHARACTER PORTRAIT Provide an official portrait for campaign records, tokens, handouts, and guild documents.	DICE Choose the preferred dice type and the character's official dice set.
PHYSICAL SOURCEBOOKS Bring or make available every book required by the character's options.	OPTIONAL PAPER SHEET A physical character sheet may be used or provided when desired.

12. FINAL CHARACTER REVIEW

Complete this checklist before the character is treated as ready for play. The Dungeon Master may approve a character while leaving minor details open, but mechanical sources and campaign compatibility should be settled first.

Concept and Party Fit

- ☐ One-sentence concept is complete.
- ☐ Character has a reason to adventure.
- ☐ Character has a reason to cooperate with the party.
- ☐ Character can participate without routine theft, betrayal, or refusal.
- ☐ Character has room to grow over the campaign.

Rules and Sources

- ☐ Primary rules foundation is identified.
- ☐ Every major option has a physical sourcebook.
- ☐ Source title and edition are recorded.
- ☐ No duplicate feature versions are combined.
- ☐ Cross-edition questions have been resolved.
- ☐ Standard Array is used.
- ☐ Encumbrance has been calculated.
- ☐ Level 1 equipment is complete.

World and Story

- ☐ World of origin is identified.
- ☐ Avadon lore has been confirmed with the Dungeon Master where needed.
- ☐ Backstory includes origin, turning point, relationship, burden, and goal.
- ☐ Important setting facts are approved or intentionally left open.
- ☐ Trait, ideal, bond, and flaw are recorded.
- ☐ At least one party connection has been discussed.
- ☐ Reason for joining the Guild is clear.

Campaign Materials

- ☐ D&D Beyond sheet is shared.
- ☐ Hero Forge miniature is shared.
- ☐ Character portrait is shared.
- ☐ Official dice are selected.
- ☐ Physical sourcebooks are available.
- ☐ Level 0 adjustment notes are ready.

APPROVAL *A character is approved when the player and Dungeon Master share the same understanding of who the adventurer is, how the rules work, and why the character belongs in the campaign.*

GUILD APPLICANT CHARACTER RECORD

Complete this summary for the Dungeon Master and the Guild’s campaign records. It is not a replacement for the character sheet or backstory.

Character Name: _____

Player Name: _____

Pronouns: _____

World of Origin: _____

Homeland / Culture: _____

Species / Lineage: _____

Background: _____

Class and Intended Subclass: _____

Primary Rules Foundation: _____

One-Sentence Concept: _____

Reason for Joining the Guild: _____

Reason for Remaining with the Party: _____

Most Important Bond: _____

Greatest Burden or Flaw: _____

Long-Term Goal: _____

Legacy the Character Hopes to Leave: _____

Sourcebooks Required

Book Title	Options Used	Edition / Year

Approval

Player Signature / Date	Dungeon Master Approval / Date



JOIN THE GUILD. FORGE YOUR PATH. SHAPE YOUR DESTINY.